
Orientation & Celebration · July 15, 2026

SPEAKER REFERENCE GUIDE

Move-In Day

What the Packing List Doesn't Cover

PHASE 1

***Prepare to be
Prepared***

Before You Leave

PHASE 2

Start Strong

Move-In Day

PHASE 3

Stay Strong

First 48 Hours

10 tips in three phases

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Prepare to be Prepared

01 Set up, and read your school email

- Move-in details (room assignment, check-in window, roommate contact, orientation date & time) go to your school email, not your personal email
- Set it up as soon as possible. Check it this week.
- UC Berkeley, UCSC, UC Davis, Cal Poly SLO, and UCSD likely use assigned time slots

Sources: [1][2][3][4]

02 Call your roommate

- Coordinate: who's bringing the mini fridge, microwave, rug
- Check your housing portal for room dimensions. Many schools post them
- One conversation now smoothes the path forward and avoids awkward moments on arrival
- Cal Poly first-year rooms are primarily triples, not doubles

Sources: [5][6]

03 Pull together your personal documents

- Gov't ID, health insurance card, immunization records, financial aid letter, Social Security card
- Physical copies + photo of each on your phone
- At 18, federal law transfers your medical and school records to you. Parents lose automatic access. Consider completing a HIPAA release form.
- HIPAA release form: sign before you leave, file at campus health on arrival. Search your school's website for instructions.

SPEAKER NOTE

Emphasize the HIPAA point. This is as important for parents as it is for students.

Sources: [7]

04 **If you're flying: ship, don't check**

- 3 checked bags round-trip: likely \$300–\$400 in fees; UPS or FedEx Ground may be cheaper
- Consider College Boxes or Storage Scholars. These are companies that pick up, ship, store, and deliver your belongings and they partner with colleges
- Fly with 1 week of essentials: clothes, meds, laptop, chargers, toiletries, 1 set of bedding
- Ship to arrive 2–3 days after you get there, not before; Pack bedding last so it comes out first.
- Most mailrooms hold packages 3–7 days; you must be there to retrieve them
- Use Lyft from the airport: find the rideshare zone before you exit baggage claim. You may need to walk, and a rolling cart helps

Sources: [9][10][11][12][13]

05 **Research your arrival before you leave home**

- Find your check-in location. At some schools, it's not your dorm building
- Do this as soon as possible. Save the address in Google Maps
- Find the drop-off and unloading zone for your dorm. Most schools post move-in maps
- Find out where carts are stored (usually at check-in or dorm entrance)
- Know your mailroom location and hours if packages are arriving
- Know when your dining hall opens and how to activate your meal plan
- Know your freshman orientation schedule — when it starts, what's required, and what to bring
- Know where and how to get your Student ID

Sources: [5][14][15][16]

Start Strong

06 Know how you're getting there and what happens when you arrive

- Everyone: Plan to arrive early to try and be the first in your room. The first one in the room gets first choice of spaces.
- **Driving:** use the temporary unloading zone, not a regular spot; move the car before hauling; someone should stay with it
- **Lyft / drop-off:** have the driver stop at the unloading zone; find a cart before moving bags; plan on multiple trips
- **Traveling alone:** ask a move-in volunteer or your RA to help with bags — that's what they're there for
- Remember: everyone on move-in day is figuring it out. You're not alone.

Sources: [5][14][15]

07 Complete your room condition report carefully

- Your RA may walk you through it on arrival and record existing damage
- Anything not on that report at move-out can be charged to you
- Take photos of any damage. That's your evidence if ever needed
- One student was charged \$300 for a dresser that was never in her room

Sources: [17][18][19]

08 Choose your bed. Then make it.

- Before unpacking: wipe everything down (desk, dresser, windowsill)
- Choose your bed. The location helps define your personal space. If you don't get your preferred location, don't sweat it, you may be able to change it later.
- Make the bed before anything else.
- A made bed makes the room feel like somewhere you actually live
- As you're unpacking and settling in, leave your door open
- Everyone on the hall is nervous and wants to make connections. Be the one who makes it easy

Sources: [5][20][21]

09 After your room is set up

- Meet your RA. They're there to help. They know the building, the rules, and have experience with dorm life. Introduce yourself and remember their name.
- Put their number in your phone. They'll be a resource for information and help all year.
- Attend Freshman Orientation. Don't skip this. That's where you'll get many questions answered, meet other students, and make early bonds with new friends.
- You'll meet more neighbors met in 2 open-door hours than in 2 closed-door weeks

Sources: [5][22]

Stay Strong

10 Be kind to yourself

- What you feel in the first weeks is normal: stress, loneliness, uncertainty
- Everyone is feeling the same thing, whether they show it or not.
- High school provided structure. College gives you freedom. Learning to manage that change takes time.
- Things that actually help:
 - Find the five places you'll need all year: dining hall, health center, financial aid office, library, your first classroom
 - Know how to activate your meal plan
 - Find the gym and get a workout in
 - Go to the events that are scheduled, especially in the first week
 - Say yes to one thing you didn't plan to do
- Keep in mind: you're not behind. You're right on time.

Sources: [26][27][28]

SOURCE NOTES

For verification, updates, and future cycle research.

[1] UC Berkeley Housing — Move-In 2026

housing.berkeley.edu/living-on-campus/move-in/
Assigned time slot system; Aug 17–19, 2026.

[2] UC Santa Cruz Housing — Move-In

housing.ucsc.edu/move-in/
Appointment-based by college; slot from housing portal.

[3] UC Davis Student Housing — Move-In FAQ

housing.ucdavis.edu/moving-in/residence-halls/faq/
Appointment-only; Sept 16–18, 2026.

[4] Cal Poly SLO — First-Year Housing FAQ

housing.calpoly.edu/content/frequently-asked-questions
First-year rooms primarily triples; SLO Days mandatory.

[5] Sleepyhead 2026 College Move-In Survival Guide

sleepyheadusa.com/blogs/sleepyhead-university/...
Primary practical source: window, roommate, room dimensions, bed first, open door.

[6] The Dorm Guide — How to Prepare and Pack

thedormguide.com/pack-for-dorm-college-move-in-day/
Room dimensions in housing portal; coordinate shared items.

[7] Etch Financial — Legal Documents Before College

etchfinancial.com/before-your-kid-leaves-for-college...
FERPA + HIPAA transfer at 18; hospitals not required to inform family without release.

[9] Storage Scholars — Flying to College Shipping Guide

storagescholars.com/blog/flying-to-college-shipping-guide
Airline fee math vs. shipping; ship 2–3 days after arrival.

[10] The Dorm Guide — Long Distance College Move

thedormguide.com/dorm-plan-for-long-distance-college-move/
Ship ahead programs.

[11] Leisurely Linds — Flying Alone Tips

leisurelylinds.com/tips-for-flying-alone-for-beginners/
2 hours early; plan ground transport before landing.

[12] Gap360 — First Time Flying Solo

gap360.com/guidebook/first-time-flying-solo...
Download airline app; security procedure.

[13] PreFlight Airport Parking — First Time Flying

preflightairportparking.com/travel-tips/...
Offline Google Maps; rideshare zones differ from baggage claim.

[14] U.S. News — Move-In Day Tips

usnews.com/education/.../what-college-freshmen-should-expect-on-move-in-day
Assigned slots for elevator/parking; room condition report process.

[15] CollegiateParent — Parent-to-Parent Advice

collegiateparent.com/family-life/parent-to-parent-advice...
Financial aid office as most-used freshman resource.

[16] McKendree University — Move-In Pro-Tips

mckendree.edu/offices/marketing/blog/move-in-guide.php
Keep ID accessible; dress practically.

[17–19] Room Condition Report Sources

thefashionspot.com · usnews.com · mckendree.edu
Real account: charged \$300–\$500 for missing dresser.
Wipe all surfaces before unpacking.

[20–22] Unpack Sequence + RA Sources

sleepyheadusa.com · thedormguide.com · summer.harvard.edu
Bed first, then desk, closet, bathroom kit. RA role and roommate conflict resolution.

[26–28] First 48 Hours Sources

collegedata.com · berry.edu · hercampus.com
46% least prepared for academics; financial aid office most used (51%); disorientation universal.

RESEARCH GAPS FOR FUTURE CYCLES

- Reddit (r/college, r/firstgencollege) — richest source of unfiltered student voice. Search "move-in day tips" and "what I wish I knew."
- College Boxes: confirm current pricing, school coverage, and booking flow before July 15. Add direct link to student take-home.
- Dorm-direct shipping: confirm which schools in the cohort allow pre-arrival packages and the exact mailing address format per school.
- School-specific pages not yet confirmed for all 41 students. UC system and Cal Poly represent the plurality.
- Best future source: the 2026 cohort itself. Add to September outreach: "What's one thing you'd tell next year's class before move-in day?"